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Insight into the Better Argument: Habermas and Lonergan

CHRISTIAAN JACOBS-VANDEGEER *

ABSTRACT: *In the first half of this article, the author argues that the notion of criticizability plays a central role in the communicative rationality that Jürgen Habermas proposes. He also identifies the incurable errors that Habermas recognizes in the philosophy of consciousness, and explains how Habermas thinks the concept of communicative rationality overcomes these errors. At the end of this discussion, he shows how the theory of communicative action suffers from vague and unsatisfying treatments of the key philosophical issues of cognition and objectivity, and suggests that these deficiencies in the theory result from Habermas's desire to avoid all things subject-centered and metaphysical. In the latter half of the article, the author discusses the cognitional theory of Bernard Lonergan and shows how it (1) avoids the legitimate criticisms Habermas raises against the philosophy of consciousness and (2) supplements and complements the theory of communicative action.*

KEY WORDS: *Argumentation; Austin, J. L. (John Langshaw) (1911-1960); Being; Cognition; Cognitional activity; Communication; Communicative action; Communicative rationality; Consciousness; Habermas, Jürgen (1929-); Identity; Illocutionary acts; Justification; Knowledge; Language; Lifeworld; Lonergan, Bernard (1904-1984); Meaning; Perlocutionary acts; Speech act; Subject; Truth; Validity.*

RESUMO: *Na primeira parte do presente artigo, o autor defende que a noção de criticabilidade desempenha um papel central na racionalidade comunicativa proposta por Jürgen Habermas. Aí são também identificados os erros insanáveis que Habermas reconhece na filosofia da consciência, e se explica de que modo Habermas pensa que o conceito de racionalidade comunicativa supera esses erros. No final da discussão, porém, o autor do artigo mostra até que ponto a teoria da acção comunicativa padece de tratamentos vagos e insatisfatórios de questões filosóficas chave relativas à cognição e à objectividade, sugerindo que estas deficiências na teoria resultam do desejo de Habermas de evitar tudo o que seja centrado no sujeito e de natureza metafísica. Na segunda grande porção do artigo, o autor discute a teoria cognitiva de Bernard Lonergan procurando demonstrar de que modo ela (1) evita as críticas legítimas de Habermas relativamente à filosofia da consciência e (2) suplementa e complementa a teoria da acção comunicativa.*

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PALAVRAS-CHAVE: *Acção comunicativa; Actividade cognitiva; Acto de linguagem; Actos elocucionários; Actos perlocucionários; Argumentação; Austin, J. L. (John Langshaw) (1911-1960); Cognição; Comunicação; Conhecimento; Consciência; Habermas, Jürgen (1929-); Identidade; Justificação; Linguagem; Lonergan, Bernard (1904-1984); Mundo-da-vida; Racionalidade comunicativa; Sentido; Ser; Sujeito; Validade; Verdade.*

1. Introduction

In his *Theory of Communicative Action*, Jürgen Habermas develops his proposal for a communicative rationality partly in response to the insurmountable errors that he identifies in the “philosophy of consciousness.” Though Bernard Lonergan advanced a philosophy of consciousness, his cognitional theory avoids the legitimate criticisms of Habermas and preserves the genuine achievements of thinkers associated with the “turn to the subject” in modern philosophy.

In this article, I argue that Lonergan’s subject-centered philosophy complements the communication model of rationality that Habermas proposes.¹ The majority of the article focuses on an explication of central themes in Habermas’s theory of reason in order to clarify the specific ways in which he believes his work overcomes the traditional problems of idealism and metaphysics. In the first major section, then, I set out to establish the thesis that the notion of criticizability provides the key to the concept of a communicative rationality articulated in terms of the reconstructive analysis that Habermas calls, “formal pragmatics.”² The final discussion demonstrates both the uniqueness of the philosophy of consciousness that Lonergan names, “critical realism,” and the supplementing complement that it offers to Habermas’s proposal.

2. Beyond Consciousness: Communicative Reason and Criticizability

In the first several pages of his major work, Habermas claims that the notion of criticizability, when narrowly confined to statements admitting propositional truth, insufficiently characterizes the concept of rationality.³

¹ A slightly different version of this article, titled “Insight into the Better Argument: Consciousness, Communication and Criticizability in Habermas and Lonergan,” appeared in *Method: Journal of Lonergan Studies*. 22 (2004).

² “Reconstructive,” because it clarifies the scope of possible communication within a given worldview according to the universal conditions for communication presupposed in the interactions of speakers and hearers oriented to reaching understanding. “Formal pragmatics” specifies precisely these communication conditions.

³ Jürgen HABERMAS – *The Theory of Communicative Action*. Volume One: *Reason and the Rationalization of Society*. Translated by Thomas McCarthy. Boston: Beacon Press, 1984, p. 10 (henceforth *TCA*).

With this claim, Habermas sets up a contrast between two basic types of reason. On one side, Habermas identifies the cognitive-instrumental core of a purposive rationality restricted both *practically* to strategic interventions in an objective world – presupposed as a totality of states of affairs – and *epistemically* to a cognitive activity of representation. Particularly since Kant, the objectivating activity of the self-referential subject has provided the basis for an overly abstract and narrowly conceived concept of reason. Though Habermas traces the dominant characteristics of this problematic notion of rationality through its diverse philosophical manifestations, he seems to attribute a kind of paradigmatic status to the basic error written into the very point of departure of the philosophy of consciousness. With subject-centered reason, preoccupied by the observer attitude of the third person, “rationality is assessed by how the isolated subject orients himself to representational and propositional contents.”⁴

On the other side of the contrast, Habermas defines a concept of communicative rationality in terms of the formal pragmatic presuppositions of speakers and hearers oriented to reaching understanding through the linguistic practice of mutually raising criticizable validity claims. The communication model focuses upon processes of interpretation undertaken by participants who have adopted the performative attitude of an “I-you” relationship in order to coordinate their actions according to the mechanism of mutual understanding. Habermas emphasizes that with ordinary linguistic practices, actors presuppose that their communication occurs and develops without undue constraints, force or coercion, and that discourse follows only the cooperative quest for truth.⁵ The counterfactual element of the ideal speech situation underscores the inherent telos for consensus in communicative action and enlivens an overall project guided by a critical interest in emancipation from distorted forms of communication extending to the entire community.

With the turn from the monological subject to the dialogical paradigm of mutual understanding, rationality encompasses three formal world-relations. Actors engage in communication with an interest in coming to an understanding not only about the objectively described world of states of affairs, but also about the normatively regulated domain of the social world, and about the expressive world of subjectivity. The primacy of the objective world as an ontological presupposition in the cognitive-instrumental model of reason yields to the primacy of the conditions for communication under which “the

⁴ Jürgen HABERMAS – “An Alternative Way out of the Philosophy of the Subject: Communicative versus Subject-Centered Reason.” In: *The Philosophical Discourse of Modernity*. Translated by Frederick Lawrence. Cambridge: MIT Press, 1987, p. 314.

⁵ For a concise discussion of the “ideal speech situation,” cf. J. HABERMAS – *The Theory of Communicative Action*, vol. 1, p. 25.

world gains objectivity” as an achievement against the common background of an intersubjectively shared lifeworld.⁶ Though this article does not address the lifeworld concept in detail, I simply point out that communicative action both relies upon the lifeworld for a linguistic reservoir or common fund of implicit meanings and enables reproduction of the lifeworld through communicative achievements.

Habermas establishes three basic types of validity claims characteristic of communicative utterances: propositional, normative, and expressive.⁷ Speakers appeal to “normative contexts recognized as legitimate” in making claims to normative rightness for particular actions, or they appeal to subjective manifestations in making claims to the truthfulness or sincerity of expressions. In either case, the knowledge embodied in these distinct types of validity claims “does not refer to the existence of states of affairs but to the validity of norms or to the manifestation of subjective experiences.”⁸ Habermas introduces notions of normative rightness and subjective truthfulness as “truth-analogous” concepts in order to speak of validity claims of the normative and expressive type as properly “criticizable,” i.e., as supported by reasons and open to the “yes” or “no” position of a hearer.⁹ Because each validity claim specifies a corresponding formal world-relation, the type of validity attached to a respective claim varies with the semantic form of a given sentence. In other words, the process of “grounding” a particular speech-act with reasons changes, depending upon the semantic need for a description of facts, a recognition of the legitimacy of norms, or an affirmation of the speaker’s sincerity.¹⁰

In opposition to the reliance of teleological actions upon strategic force, actions coordinated by a properly communicative rationality depend upon the *rationality motivating force* of the better argument. Communicative actions presuppose discursive collaboration for “achieving, sustaining, and renew-

⁶ J. HABERMAS – *The Theory of Communicative Action*, vol. 1, pp. 12-13.

⁷ The reader may also note that Habermas distinguishes two other types of claims in addition to the three basic categories listed. He points to evaluative claims that represent a type of expressive utterance distinct from self-presentations; and he recognizes that participants can rationally criticize linguistic usage itself, i.e. “the comprehensibility, well-formedness, or rule-correctness of symbolic expressions.” cf. J. HABERMAS – *The Theory of Communicative Action*, vol. 1, pp. 16, 22.

⁸ *Ibid.*, p. 16.

⁹ For a more detailed account of “truth-analogous” concepts, cf. Jürgen HABERMAS – “Toward a Critique of the Theory of Meaning.” In: *Postmetaphysical Thinking: Philosophical Essays*. Translated by William Mark Hohengarten. Cambridge: MIT Press, 1992, pp. 75-76. By way of refinement, Habermas also points out that though evaluative and expressive speech-acts are not directly invested with clear-cut validity claims, they nevertheless “satisfy the central presupposition of rationality: they can be defended against criticism.” cf. J. HABERMAS – *The Theory of Communicative Action*, vol. 1, p. 16.

¹⁰ J. HABERMAS – *The Theory of Communicative Action*, vol. 1, p. 39.

ing... a consensus that rests on the intersubjective recognition of criticizable validity claims.”¹¹ Habermas aligns the concept of communicative rationality with a theory of argumentation on the basis of the essential experience of rationally motivated agreement. Argumentation provides the link to the experience. In fact, the binding force of communicative utterances originates not with the “validity of what is said” but with “*the coordinating effect of the warranty*” offered in the speech act, that is, with the capacity “to redeem [with reasons], if necessary, the validity claim raised with [the] speech act.”¹² Despite the insufficiency of the cognitive-instrumental model, the capacity for criticizability in argumentative speech remains central to rational assessment in the paradigm of communication theory.

3. The Internal Relation of Meaning and Validity

Habermas recalls Karl-Otto Apel’s recognition of the peculiar way in which the ideal communication community and the real one become “entwined” with the doubled character of validity claims. Participants in interaction presuppose, for communication, not only the absence of deceit, manipulation and force, but also the universalizable acceptance of the reasons grounding the validity of their claims. Validity claims *qua claims* retain a transcendental moment that exceeds the borders of particular localities; but, *as raised*, they pertain to their relevant contexts and obtain “the social currency of a de facto established practice.”¹³

This brings us to an important point with regards to the counterfactual of the ideal speech situation. As a formal-pragmatic presupposition, the counterfactual stands as a universal condition for communication. As theoretically significant, it allows us to speak of rationality in the *singular* – that is, it signifies a general, invariant feature of discourse – and it serves to show that the consensus-building force of rationally motivated agreement originates with an exigency not solely for consensus itself, but for (intersubjective) recognition of *validity*. Communicative rationality presupposes that speech situations, driven by the cooperative quest for truth and liberated from systemic distortions, will arrive at their precise goal: truth (cooperatively achieved). Again borrowing from Apel, Habermas points to the performative contradiction necessarily involved in any attempt to deny or disprove the formal-pragmatic presuppositions of communication. In arguing against these general features of discourse, one inevitably supposes that a universal communication community, freed from distortive pressures, could corroborate the validity

¹¹ Idem, p. 17.

¹² Idem, p. 302.

¹³ J. HABERMAS – “Communicative versus Subject-Centered Reason,” pp. 322-323.

of the claim, in view of the fulfillment of its conditions, through a common affirmation of reasons.

Given that understanding and agreement depend upon the rational force of reasons, questions of meaning stand inseparably tied to questions of validity. Habermas takes over this “crucial insight” from the propositional semantics of Frege, and attributes to it “the key” to a theory of meaning.¹⁴ For Habermas, however, the internal relation of meaning and validity grounds the range of linguistic forms, including propositional, normative, and expressive utterances. Across this range, the “formal-pragmatic explanation of meaning” brings together three interrelated and indispensable concepts: understanding, validity, and agreement. Understanding a speech-act implies not only a comprehension of the reasons inherent to its meaning, but also knowledge of “how one can make use of it in order to reach an understanding with somebody about something.”¹⁵

Habermas emphasizes that linguistic utterances serve the purpose of bringing about an agreement, and, moreover, an agreement defined by its validity. If the telos of communicative rationality heads towards consensus, we must understand this orientation in light of the strong emphasis upon the internal relation of meaning and validity. This brings us to important questions regarding the nature of the relation between language and the world(s), validity and the real, meaning and knowing.

We understand a speech act when we are acquainted with the kind of reasons that a speaker could cite in order to convince a hearer that he (the speaker) is entitled under the given circumstances to claim validity for his utterance. For this reason, familiarity with a language is interwoven with knowledge of how things do actually stand in the (linguistically disclosed) world. *Perhaps* knowledge of the world merely depends upon a longer chain of reasons than knowledge of language [italics mine].¹⁶

The word, *perhaps*, in the final sentence of the quote above should draw our attention to an ambiguity lingering in a theory of meaning developed from the philosophy of language (-with-a-pragmatic-turn). Habermas underscores the inseparability of language and the world, but he neglects to give an explicit account of how these two finally meet within the internal relation of meaning and validity. If validity depends upon acceptable reasons, what makes the reasons themselves valid, presuming the uncoerced quality of the discourse? How does one identify the fulfillment of conditions of validity? What is the status of an affirmation of a criticizable validity claim qua affirmation (be it propositional, normative, or expressive)?

¹⁴ J. HABERMAS – “Toward a Critique of the Theory of Meaning,” pp. 61-62.

¹⁵ Ibid., p. 78.

¹⁶ Idem.

To be sure, when Habermas takes over Frege's insight that "facts are what *make* assertoric sentences *true*,"¹⁷ he also criticizes this model, as well as the truth-semantic conceptualization worked out by Searle, on grounds that they narrowly confine meaning and validity to the propositional content of speech-acts. Habermas introduces the "truth-analogous" concepts of normative rightness and subjective truthfulness in order to expand the scope of the theory of meaning and to account for the formal semantic differences entailed by these distinct types of validity claims. He readily admits the centrality of validity for the relation between language and the world(s). However, his shift to a pragmatically oriented theory of language seems to release him from any need to explain concepts such as "objectivity," which would clarify words such as "facts" and "truth." Could these suspiciously bracketed terms not pertain to all three formal world- concepts? Or is this, in fact, Habermas's goal? We will return to these questions at a later point.

With the extension of the internal relation of meaning and validity into normative and expressive domains, our assessment of rationality moves further away from the fallacies of the philosophy of consciousness. Habermas repeatedly criticizes the consciousness paradigm for restricting its epistemic criteria to truth and its practical criteria to success.¹⁸ The priority of the subject relating to itself, as it would to an objective entity in the world, leads to an internally disturbed model of rationality confined to the cognitive-instrumental dimension of reason. Habermas gives the philosophy of consciousness a diagnosis of exhaustion.¹⁹ He emphatically states that consciousness has exhausted itself in the "transcendental gap between the intelligible and empirical worlds"; the self-referential subject endlessly labors against the tension between these two poles within the mediating activity of an idealizing synthesis (Kant).²⁰ Representation and manipulation offer themselves as the only activities available at the disposal of subject-centered reason.

4. Communicative vs. Strategic Action

The reconstructive science of formal pragmatics focuses upon "the pretheoretical grasp of rules on the part of competently speaking, acting, and knowing subjects."²¹ The task of mutual understanding – at times precarious and always risky – interrupts the success orientations of teleological actions defined by exertions of influence on someone or some objective entity or state

¹⁷ Idem, p. 61.

¹⁸ J. HABERMAS – "Communicative versus Subject-Centered Reason," p. 314.

¹⁹ Jürgen HABERMAS – "The Unity of Reason in the Diversity of Its Voices." In: *Postmetaphysical Thinking: Philosophical Essays*, op. cit., pp. 142, 117.

²⁰ Ibid., p. 117.

²¹ J. HABERMAS – "Communicative versus Subject-Centered Reason," pp. 297-298.

of affairs. For Habermas, strategic and communicative actions not only differ analytically, but also, from the shared perspective of participants in communication, exclude each other *as types of interaction*.²² Habermas emphasizes that communication serves the purpose of mutual understanding. Within communication, participants cannot pursue instrumental actions aimed at causally influencing something in the external world and simultaneously achieve rationally motivated agreements. For this reason, Habermas opposes illocutionary and perlocutionary acts.

Borrowing terminology from Austin, Habermas defines locutionary acts as propositions, illocutionary acts as performative utterances that establish the mode of a sentence and, in the process, secure an intersubjective relation with an addressee, and perlocutionary acts as the effects or consequences of the speech-act.²³ Habermas characterizes the three acts as follows: “to say *something*, to act *in* saying something, to bring about something *through* acting in saying something.”²⁴ One may notice that the italicized “through” preceded by the “to bring about” intention of perlocutions, places these kinds of acts in the strategic context of manipulation that Habermas opposes to communicative action. Without getting into a detailed discussion of the controversial relation between illocutionary and perlocutionary acts, I simply want to indicate two points at which Habermas distinguishes his understanding from that of Austin.

First, Habermas differentiates (where Austin failed to) between *interactions* governed solely by the pursuit of illocutionary aims, and the type of interactions characterized by the parasitic presence of perlocutions.²⁵ For example, a host who drags out a story with the explicit purpose of preventing guests from leaving early pursues perlocutionary aims within the performative (illocutionary) act of story-telling. Again, Habermas sharply separates illocutionary and perlocutionary acts. The latter aims require concealment and thus imply deceit, whereas the former aims *must* make themselves fully known. Illocutions by nature are “self-identifying”; they openly express the communicative intent of the speaker, i.e., how the speaker wants the hearer to understand the speech-act offer.²⁶ Whether as a command, promise, confession, or explana-

²² J. HABERMAS – “Toward a Critique of the Theory of Meaning,” p. 81.

²³ J. HABERMAS – *The Theory of Communicative Action*, vol. 1, pp. 288-289. We should also note that “sentences” and “speech-acts” seem to differ, for Habermas, according to the generality of the former and the relative specificity of the latter. Sentences may take on different structures and contents in a multiplicity of forms, *and* may also be *analytically* restricted to a monological treatment. Every speech-act, however, incorporates an illocutionary component, regardless of the type of validity claim brought forth in the speech-act, and therefore serves a more *pragmatic* function.

²⁴ J. HABERMAS – *The Theory of Communicative Action*, vol. 1, p. 289.

²⁵ *Ibid.*, p. 294.

²⁶ *Idem*, pp. 290-292.

tion, the illocutionary act secures the intersubjective relation. By contrast, Habermas regards perlocutions “as a special class of strategic interactions in which illocutions are employed as means in teleological contexts of action.”²⁷ Though speakers can employ speech-acts for strategic purposes, perlocutions obtain nothing more than a parasitic status, i.e., they depend upon the rational structure of communicative action. Only the unrestricted and *singular* pursuit of illocutionary aims, by which “*all* participants harmonize their individual plans of action with one another,” signifies for Habermas, “the original use of language,” and characterizes the type of interaction he calls, “communicative action.”²⁸

Furthermore, actions coordinated through the mechanism of mutual understanding do not count as perlocutionarily achieved effects. Habermas writes, “Whether the expected consequences [of rationally motivated agreements] actually come to pass or not has no effect on the illocutionary success of the speaker.”²⁹ Habermas identifies the performance of these action-expectations with “the fulfillment of an obligation the addressee [*takes*] upon himself with his ‘yes’ to a speech act offer” [*italics mine*].³⁰ Thus, illocutionary success may entail *expectation*, but does not in any way take the action itself as a measure. Actions per se represent a *further step* beyond the coordinating function of mutual understanding.

A second point at which Habermas distinguishes his theory from Austin’s pertains to the primary significance of illocutionary aims for speech-acts. Austin early on regarded what he called the “illocutionary force” of a speech act as its “literally irrational component.”³¹ He limited the rational content of the sentence to the assertoric part, which he identified with the locutionary act. Habermas, however, denies that these descriptors (“rational” and “irrational”), attached respectively to locutions and (“misleadingly named”) illocutions, follow from what amounts to no more than an analytic difference. Austin picked up on this point but failed to develop sufficiently the important observation behind it: that all speech-acts incorporate a double structure composed of two acts, separable only *analytically*. “In general, the speaker carries out an illocutionary act *by saying something*.”³² The double structure of all speech-acts exposes the error in the opposition between (illocutionary) “force” and (locutionary) “meaning.” Not only do performative sentences “obviously have just as clear a meaning as assertoric sentences,” but the latter also “exhibit the

²⁷ Idem, pp. 293-294.

²⁸ Idem.

²⁹ Idem, p. 291.

³⁰ Idem.

³¹ J. HABERMAS – “Toward a Critique of the Theory of Meaning,” pp. 70, 74.

³² Ibid., p. 70.

same illocutionary-propositional double structure as all other speech acts.”³³ For example, the performative sentence, “I thee wed,” has a clear “meaning” that belongs to a specific normative context without needing to conform to an assertoric statement for achieving comprehensibility. Also, Habermas points out that descriptions, explanations and assertions, “can be infelicitous in a way similar to other illocutionary acts: one can make such a mess of a story that it ‘is no longer a tale,’ or discuss a delicate matter so bluntly that those present ‘will not tolerate any further discussion of it.’”³⁴

Habermas argues that when we revoke the “special status” that accrues to locutionary acts identified as keepers of the rational content of communicative utterances, and thus accord primacy to illocutions,³⁵ we discover the linguistic space for other types of speech-acts (i.e. normative rightness and expressive truthfulness). In fact, every speech-act, considered as a whole, presupposes all three formal world-relations and can thus “be criticized as invalid from three perspectives”: states of affairs, legitimacy of norms, or truthfulness of expressions.³⁶ The *thematization* of an individual speech-act, however, emphasizes a particular type of validity claim, intensifies a corresponding formal world-relation, and finally defines the illocutionary act. Moreover, the illocutionary mode not only establishes the communicative intent of the speaker (i.e., how the hearer should receive the speech-act offer, e.g., as a warning, an explanation, etc.), but also creates the linguistic space for criticizability. In other words, the illocutionary force of a speech-act expresses “the speaker’s demand that the hearer *ought* to accept a sentence as true or sincere,” or, of course, legitimate.³⁷

With the pragmatic turn, the distinct *type* of claim raised in a speech-act offer through an illocutionary act binds the speech-act to the validity claim, the conditions of its validity, and the reasons given in its support.³⁸ Validity claims serve as the “stewards of a rationality” that resides in the capacity of the linguistic structure of speech-acts for criticizability. “The home of rationality” thereby shifts “from the propositional to the illocutionary component.”³⁹ The pragmatic and fundamental role of the illocutionary act secures the primacy

³³ Idem.

³⁴ Idem.

³⁵ Though Habermas surely states that, “everything that can be said at all can be said in assertoric form,” he underscores the pragmatic importance of illocutions for communication. Performative sentences account for the speaker-hearer relationship. cf. Jürgen HABERMAS – *The Theory of Communicative Action*. Volume Two: *Lifeworld and System: A Critique of Functionalist Reason*. Translated by Thomas McCarthy. Boston: Beacon Press, 1987, pp. 64-70.

³⁶ J. HABERMAS – “Toward a Critique of the Theory of Meaning,” p. 77.

³⁷ J. HABERMAS – *The Theory of Communicative Action*, vol. 2, p. 69.

³⁸ J. HABERMAS – “Toward a Critique of the Theory of Meaning,” p. 74.

³⁹ Ibid., p. 75.

of intersubjectivity given within a linguistic capacity for criticizability. Thus, for Habermas, “the smallest independent unit” of (“explicitly linguistic”) processes of reaching understanding includes not only an elementary speech-act attached to at least one validity claim, but also the “yes” or “no” response of the hearer.⁴⁰ The primacy of illocutionary components stems from the telos immanent in communication oriented to the intersubjective recognition of criticizable validity claims. As Habermas writes, “Mutual understanding aims at consensus formation.”⁴¹

I will return to the inseparable relation that Habermas draws between criticizability and intersubjectivity in a discussion of post-traditional identity structures. But first, recall that Habermas opposes strategic and communicative actions and connects the assumptions of the former with the ingrained fallacies of the philosophy of consciousness. Communicative action embraces three formal world-relations and their corresponding types of validity claims. The ontological presuppositions of idealism turn into “trivial suppositions of communality” in everyday language use, providing the purely heuristic scope of linguistic possibilities.⁴² The pragmatic orientation to reaching understanding supplements the *objectivating attitude* of the third person perspective with the *expressive attitude* of first person presentations and the *norm-conformative attitude* adopted in the second person for social contexts defined by legitimacy-expectations.⁴³

5. Post-Traditional Identity Formation

Habermas concentrates his analysis on the linguistic structure of communication and the performative perspective of the “I-you” relationship adopted by participants attempting to convince one another of the validity of their claims. The interlocking system of personal pronouns takes on a double significance for Habermas in this regard.

As mentioned above, the system of personal pronouns corresponds to attitudes adopted in conjunction with particular types of validity claims raised by participants in communication. Reason expresses the diversity of its voices through the grammatical transitions that make possible these different attitudes within discourse (objectivating, norm-conformative and expressive). Recall, however, that although every speech-act raises a distinct type of validity claim, hearers can criticize speech-acts on all three levels (e.g. the sincerity of the speaker, the truth of the statement, the legitimacy of the norm

⁴⁰ Idem, p. 74.

⁴¹ Idem

⁴² J. HABERMAS – “The Unity of Reason in the Diversity of its Voices,” p. 142.

⁴³ J. HABERMAS – *The Theory of Communicative Action*, vol. 1, pp. 309, 236-237.

or action). The unity of reason asserts itself within the formal-pragmatic relations presupposed by communication-participants, who have sufficient mastery of a language. In other words, actors engage all three formal world-relations with their speech-acts and transition between attitudes in discourse without difficulty. In the balanced tension between the inner logic of the dominant form of argumentation appropriate to a distinct type of validity claim and the grammatical transitions that connect the various moments of reason throughout discourse, the unity of rational inquiry triumphs. Thus, the capacity for criticizability reasserts itself with the unity of reason in the diversity of many voices.

We come here to a major intersection for the themes of intersubjectivity and criticizability. The second important point that Habermas makes in regard to the grammatically inter-linked personal pronouns concerns the role of this system in what he calls post-traditional identity formation. Drawing on the writings of G. H. Mead, Habermas argues that the process of individuation coincides with the process of socialization. For Mead, these linguistically mediated processes occur in communication contexts and conform to the linguistic structure of interaction. Only when ego develops the capacity to relate to alter in the second person ("you"), does the ego's identity begin to form around a "me" capable of internalizing alter's expectations. The process of socialization appears in the lens of the interactive context defined by the ego's offer of the "me" to alter, by which ego comes to an understanding of what alter expects of *me*, promises *me*, that alter pleases *me*, angers *me*, likes *me*, rejects *me*.⁴⁴

The individuating effects of this process arise concurrently. Habermas underscores the impossibility of erasing the space for freedom etched into the linguistic structure of the socialization process. The interpersonal relation between the first and second persons requires that the former take responsibility for responding to alter. And ego's accountability in this interaction depends upon the presupposition that "I" can take a "yes" or "no" position with regards to alter's speech-act offers. In this way, the linguistic structure of intersubjectivity generates an unavoidable necessity for the "I" to emerge in particularity and uniqueness; one is, in a sense, forced to be *oneself*. "Thus in the socialization process an 'I' emerges equiprimordially with the 'me'."⁴⁵

Moreover, ego develops the capacity for a reflective relation to self within the linguistic space for freedom. By adopting the perspective of alter, in anticipation of alter's response to ego's speech-act offer, ego can rationally assess validity claims within a reflective and interior forum for argumentation.

⁴⁴ J. HABERMAS – *The Theory of Communicative Action*, vol. 2, pp. 58-59.

⁴⁵ *Ibid.*, p. 59.

The achievement of “internalizing the role of a participant in argumentation” releases ego’s capacity for self-criticism.⁴⁶

Grammatical transitions inherent to linguistic structure make possible a general interpersonal relation within an orientation to mutual understanding. And here we directly encounter the double significance of the system of personal pronouns. The performative attitude of the “I-you” relationship conforms to the linguistic structure of the first and second persons. And, in turn, the performative attitude provides the basis for speakers and hearers to utilize the system of personal pronouns in a distinct and specific way, i.e., for mutually raising criticizable validity claims.⁴⁷ As a participant, ego can raise validity claims within distinct attitudes, at distinct levels of argumentation, in respect to distinct formal world-relations. Ego has no problem here and does not assume three distinct selves for three different attitudes (objectivating, norm-conformative, expressive). But these transitions rely upon a prior and more general relation secured in the *performative attitude* of participants. Subjectivity and intersubjectivity are coeval; and the interpenetration of these structures of identity formation relies upon the presupposition of criticizability.

For Habermas, this notion of identity formation, taken over from Mead, overcomes a serious error in the philosophy of consciousness. In the subject-centered model, the isolated reflection of the knower, relating to itself through the gap of an objectification, struggles against the inevitable loss of originality. Cognitive activity remains confined to the observer attitude of the third person with which the subject relates to everything, internal and external, in an objectivating manner. The switch over to the interactive context of mutual understanding escapes this familiar aporia of the consciousness paradigm by focusing upon the formation process of an identity that emerges within an interpersonal relationship. The original relation to self survives within the performative attitude adopted by ego in assuming the perspective of alter. The fluidity of the interaction holds together the spontaneous originality of knowing acts within the reflective relation to self, i.e. through “a recapitulating reconstruction of knowledge already employed.”⁴⁸ Habermas clearly

⁴⁶ Idem, pp. 74-75.

⁴⁷ The autonomy and accountability inherent to an identity made possible by the individuating effects of socialization processes rely, in the linguistic medium, strictly upon the *performative* use of the first person pronoun employed in the “I-you” relationship. Habermas cautions against confusion here, “But these identity claims aiming at intersubjective recognition must not be confused with the validity claims that the actor raises with his speech acts. For the ‘no’ with which the addressee rejects a speech-act offer concerns the validity of a particular utterance, not the identity of the speaker.” Cf. Jürgen Habermas – “Individuation through Socialization: On George Herbert Mead’s Theory of Subjectivity.” In: *Postmetaphysical Thinking*, op.cit., p.190.

⁴⁸ J. HABERMAS – “Communicative versus Subject-Centered Reason,” p. 297.

argues that the aporia of the philosophy of consciousness simply ceases to apply:

If, namely, the self is part of a relation-to-self that is performatively established when the speaker takes up the second-person perspective of a hearer toward the speaker, then this self is not introduced as an object... but as a subject that forms itself through participation in linguistic interaction and expresses itself in the capacity for speech and action.⁴⁹

Given that the cognitive-instrumental model simply fails to account adequately for individuality, Habermas contends that the pragmatic turn, which emphasizes the link between “the ‘I’ of the illocutionary act” and the personal accountability presupposed by autonomous actors in communication, allows us to overcome “this final and most difficult of the problems left behind by metaphysics.”⁵⁰

6. Communicative Rationality, Cognition and Objectivity

In the following passage, Habermas summarizes the basic problems of the philosophy of consciousness:

The relationship of the human being to the world is cognitivistically reduced: Ontologically, the world is reduced to the world of entities as a whole... epistemologically, our relationship to that world is reduced to the capacity to know existing states of affairs or to bring them about in a purposive-rational fashion; semantically, it is reduced to fact-stating discourse in which assertoric sentences are used – and no validity claim is admitted besides propositional truth, which is available *in foro interno*.⁵¹

In opposition to these errors, and in response to them, the theory of communicative action supplements the human relation to the (objective) world with relations to domains of expressive subjectivity and regulated normativity. It embraces the range of linguistic possibilities opened up by three formal world-relations and specifies the corresponding (basic) types of validity categories. Finally, communicative action privileges the linguistic intersubjectivity inherent to processes of interpretation through which participants coordinate their actions with the achievement of mutual understanding against the common background of an intersubjectively shared lifeworld. Through the analysis above, I have shown how the notion of criticizability – now expanded to encompass each world-relation distinctly – remains central to the concept of communicative rationality.

However, given the internal relation of meaning to validity in the formal-pragmatic theory of meaning, the question arises: What relation exists between

⁴⁹ Jürgen HABERMAS – “Metaphysics After Kant.” In: *Postmetaphysical Thinking*, op. cit., p. 25.

⁵⁰ J. HABERMAS – “The Unity of Reason in the Diversity of Its Voices,” p. 144.

⁵¹ Jürgen HABERMAS – “Communicative versus Subject-Centered Reason,” p. 311.

linguistically mediated meaning and its objective referents? The explanation anticipated by this question – the question of the relation between “meaning and meant” – requires an account of the intellectual process that generates “meaning” in cognitional achievements. How, then, do participants in communication actually *know* what they mean when they raise, accept or defend criticizable validity claims? Habermas recognizes that “yes” or “no” positions taken by hearers with respect to proposed claims, “are the expression of *insight or understanding* [*Einsicht*],”⁵² but a strong aversion to idealism and metaphysics leads him to propose a theory of rationality that seems to ignore the essential philosophical question of cognition. Resultantly, he fails to adequately address the related issue of objectivity.

In a collection of articles titled, *Truth and Justification*, Habermas acknowledges his neglect of these theoretical issues and attempts, as it were, to fill in the gap. However, his treatment seems, if not vague, at least incomplete and unsatisfying. For example, in defining cognition as “a process of intelligent, problem-solving behavior that makes learning processes possible,”⁵³ he fails to explain exactly what such “problem-solving behavior” entails. Is that intelligent process characterized by a normative pattern, or not? Is that problem-solving behavior the same for all speaking, acting and knowing subjects, or not? A proper philosophical treatment of cognition must include a fully explanatory account of the intelligent process that “cognition” is.

A similar ambiguity arises when Habermas articulates his pragmatic account of objectivity. He recognizes that words such as “facts” and “truth” generally denote statements *about* objects in the world or discursive achievements. These general definitions follow from his decision for a nominalist conception of the world as a “totality of things, not of facts.”⁵⁴ This decision remains “supported by the grammatical evidence that we cannot locate facts, in contrast to things or events, as something existing or occurring in the world;”⁵⁵ and it allows for an explanation of the ways in which experience contributes to the revision of language.

Though Habermas supports a realist notion of truth and maintains the concept of an objective world independent of language – a formal anticipation, or “trivial supposition of communality,” shared by participants in discourse, which secures continuity of reference among participants (i.e., speakers can “refer” to the same language-independent “objects” from different perspectives) – he fails to explain the connection between language and the world.

⁵² J. HABERMAS – *The Theory of Communicative Action*, vol. 1, p. 38.

⁵³ Jürgen HABERMAS – “Introduction: Realism after the Linguistic Turn.” In: *Truth and Justification*. Edited by Barbara Fultner. Cambridge: MIT Press, 2003, p. 26.

⁵⁴ *Ibid.*, pp. 31-33.

⁵⁵ *Idem*, p. 31.

Beyond pointing out that “facts” and “truth,” though justification-transcendent, are not structurally homologous with the objective world, he neglects to offer an explanatory account of how a nominalistically conceived world of objects corresponds to a realist portrait of knowing. In other words, he simply does not clarify exactly how linguistically mediated facts are cognitively obtained with respect to their language-independent referents. This failure, an inevitable consequence of an obscure account of cognition, produces paradoxical relationships between truth and justification.

In raising criticizable validity claims, speakers aspire to a truth beyond the success of their reasons (i.e., a truth independent of what we agree upon now), but their discursive achievements nevertheless remain unavoidably connected to the fallibility of their justifications.⁵⁶ Actors, on the other hand, presuppose the infallibility of their beliefs about the world in order to act with certainty. Habermas struggles to articulate the rational basis for switching from the fallibilist sensibility of a speaker to the perspective of certainty adopted by an actor. He struggles because his pragmatic account of objectivity suffers from insufficient explanations of (1) the relationship between language and the world and (2) the corresponding issue of cognition.

7. Philosophy of Consciousness Revisited

In this section, I argue that Lonergan presented a philosophy of consciousness which not only avoids the pitfalls of idealism – pitfalls appropriately rejected by Habermas – but also supplements the theory of communicative action on points of cognitional theory and objectivity. Though Habermas altogether rejected the paradigm of consciousness, Lonergan found within it the tools for explaining basic philosophical positions in a manner that ultimately complements, I contend, the major insights of communicative action.

In sharp contrast to the primacy of objectivating reflexivity in the consciousness paradigm that Habermas criticized, Lonergan described consciousness as a matter of “experience,” and he underscored the empirical basis of self-knowledge in the performative dimension of knowing. He explained that diverse sensitive and intellectual operations – e.g., “attending [to data], inquiring, understanding, conceiving, doubting, weighing the evidence, judging”⁵⁷ – include a conscious component that gives the existential subject some knowledge of him- or herself as the performative origin and centre of the operations. In other words, conscious, cognitive acts, in their cognitive

⁵⁶ Idem, p. 40.

⁵⁷ Bernard LONERGAN – “Christ as Subject: A Reply.” In: *Collection*. Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan, vol. 4. Edited by Frederick E. Crowe and Robert M. Doran. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1988, p. 166, fnnt. 14.

aspect, make objects present to a knower, but, in their conscious aspect, make the knower present to him- or herself. Thus, Lonergan described knowing as a performance, and he argued that consciousness gives the subject some immediate knowledge of the performance itself.

In fact, the inclusion of the concrete subject in the performance of knowing acts distinguishes the notion of consciousness as experience from the idealist and naïve realist notions of consciousness as perception or confrontation. Lonergan repeatedly criticized the model of perception for conceiving the process of knowing on the analogy of ocular vision, i.e., knowing as taking a good look. In rhythm with Habermas, he rejected its tendency to construe direct and reflexive knowing as an *objectivating* activity that simply misses the performative immediacy of empirical self-knowledge in consciousness. Though Habermas wants to show philosophy a complete and emergency exit from the conceptualism associated with the model of perception, Lonergan offered a non-conceptualist philosophy of consciousness that complements a universal pragmatics. In the following passage, he identified the mistaken principle at the basis of the perception theory.

The alternative, I suggest, is to deny that consciousness is a matter of knowing an object; the alternative is to deny that only objects are known; the alternative is to reject the tacit assumption that *unumquodque cognoscitur secundum quod est obiectum*, and to put in its place the familiar axiom that *unumquodque cognoscitur secundum quod est actu*. On the basis of this axiom, one can assert that whenever there is a *sensible actu* or an *intelligible actu*, an object is known; and whenever there is a *sensus actu* or an *intellectus actus*, the subject and his act are known.⁵⁸

Through or in an act, whereby an object becomes known, one is constituted as present to oneself; and such self-presence is *not* an objectivating activity, but rather a performative immediacy intrinsic to the act. Sensitive and intellectual operations render the subject present to him- or herself as the performative center of distinct knowing acts. Whether the object of an insight refers to the data of sense (as in direct knowing) or to the data of consciousness (as in reflexive knowing), the intellectual operation includes some immediate knowledge or awareness of the subject as subject. Lonergan wrote, "Now by *both* direct and reflexive operations the subject in act is constituted and known, not as object, but as subject; this constitutive knowing and being known is consciousness."⁵⁹

Unlike the idealist notion that Habermas rejects, the notion of consciousness as experience clearly does not restrict conscious activity to the observer perspective of the third person. Rather, "consciousness" denotes the self-presence component of the dynamic performance of knowing. In this line of

⁵⁸ B. LONERGAN – "Christ as Subject: A Reply," p. 165.

⁵⁹ Ibid., p. 166, ftnt. 14.

analysis, consciousness retains the originality of spontaneous knowing acts that a Kantian epistemology declares inaccessible and irretrievable. Fred Lawrence comments on the connection between Habermas and Lonergan with respect to this point.⁶⁰ Though consciousness gives some immediate knowledge of the subject as subject, Lawrence qualifies this kind of knowledge as “knowledge in an improper sense of the word.”⁶¹ For Lonergan, the proper sense of knowledge involves the compound of potential, formal, and full acts of meaning corresponding to the normative pattern of intelligent operations in experiencing, understanding, and judging.⁶² Knowledge in the “improper sense of the word” refers to potential self-knowledge in terms of “the experienced.” It accounts for the basis of self-knowledge in the performative dimension of knowing. Thus, Lonergan avoided confining the subject as subject to an objectification by identifying consciousness as the empirical basis of self-knowledge.

If consciousness marks the point of departure for the scientific self-knowledge that objectifies cognitional performance, reflexive knowing begins with an insight into the *experience* of the dynamic performance that produces insights, generates definitions in concepts, and achieves *full knowing* in acts of judgment. Again, consciousness itself accounts for the data of reflexive knowing. It represents the immediate experience of the performance that reflexive knowing thematizes. Thus, as a conscious subject, I have some experience of my own experiencing, understanding, and judging; I can understand the experience of my experiencing, understanding, and judging; and I can verify my understanding of the experience of my performance as a knower, my own experiencing, understanding and judging. Putting it simply, Lonergan wrote: “one must begin from the performance if one is to have the experience necessary for understanding what the performance is.”⁶³

In reference to this statement, Lawrence connects Lonergan’s emphasis upon the dynamic performance of knowing with the primacy of the performative attitude upon which Habermas insists. Though cognitional performance remains distinct from self-knowledge in the proper sense, the latter obtains a methodological primacy. This route seems to complement rather well the task of articulating the formal-pragmatic features of communication – features invariably presupposed in any instance of communication, whether reflected upon or not – in view of identifying the normative exigencies of communica-

⁶⁰ Frederick G. LAWRENCE – “The Fragility of Consciousness: Lonergan and the Postmodern Concern for the Other.” In: *Communication and Lonergan: Common Ground for Forging the New Age*. Edited by Thomas J. Farrell and Paul A. Soukup. Kansas City: Sheed and Ward, 1993, pp. 186-188.

⁶¹ *Ibid.*, p. 187.

⁶² Bernard LONERGAN – *Method in Theology*. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1990, p. 74.

⁶³ B. LONERGAN – “Christ as Subject: A Reply,” p. 174.

tive encounters. Since the performance reveals and establishes the contingent facticity of the normative pattern of knowing, Lawrence observes that,

inasmuch as [self-knowing] involves using our ordinary language to inquire, grasp, and formulate and then to check out and judge whether articulations of possibly relevant relationships are contingently verifiable in the experiences themselves, such self-knowledge has the quality of what Habermas, borrowing from Piaget, calls reconstruction.⁶⁴

On another point germane to Habermas' critique of the philosophy of consciousness, Lonergan's cognitional theory has no need at all of an epistemic bridge between the knower and the known. Lonergan identified himself in the Aristotelian and Thomist tradition that replaced mythical Platonic anamnesis with the psychological fact of insight into phantasm. He argued against the varieties of conceptualism in ancient, scholastic and modern philosophies, adamantly rejecting the tendency to conceive the event of knowing as a matter of confrontation with objects. Thus, Lonergan faithfully advanced the Aristotelian theorem of knowledge by perfection or identity: sense in act is the sensible in act; intellect in act is the intelligible in act.⁶⁵ He wrote, "On this view the subject in act and his act are constituted and, as well, they are known simultaneously and concomitantly with the knowledge of objects."⁶⁶

Habermas correctly identifies the exhaustion of a paradigm that struggles against the transcendental gap between the intelligible and empirical worlds. The essential Kantian element of *Anschauung* sets up an irreconcilable dilemma between the categories of understanding and the manifold of objects known in the world of mere appearances. Since cognitional operations rely solely upon intuition for their objective reference, the inaccessibility of the *noumenon* relegates *Anschauung* to the shell of phenomenality. It abandons the objectivity of knowing to the obscurity of illusion.

On the theorem of knowledge by identity, insight prescind from a supposed primordial distinction between subject and object; the distinction between meaning and meant or between knower and known arises in knowledge subsequent to the initial act of understanding.⁶⁷ The theorem of identity or perfection focuses the analysis of intellectual knowing in terms of intelligence itself rather than in those of sense or perception.⁶⁸ It clarifies the performative

⁶⁴ F. LAWRENCE – "The Fragility of Consciousness," p. 188.

⁶⁵ Bernard LONERGAN – "Imago Dei." In: *Verbum: Word and Idea in Aquinas*. Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan, vol. 2. Edited by Frederick E. Crowe and Robert M. Doran. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1997, pp. 192-193.

⁶⁶ B. LONERGAN – "Christ as Subject: A Reply," p. 165.

⁶⁷ For Lonergan, insight, prior to its expression in the inner word of understanding (i.e. a concept or definition), signifies a potential act of meaning; the distinction of meaning and meant has not yet emerged. Cf. *Method in Theology*, p. 74.

⁶⁸ Lonergan makes a related and important point on the issue of objectivity in a treatment of the dynamism of questioning. Though an "analysis of questioning forces one to conceive

character of conscious knowing, as we have seen, while specifying distinct *a posteriori* intelligible and sensible acts. Insight grasps the intelligibility immanent in the data of sense, but not given with sense. An act of understanding adds to the object of sense an element proper to intelligence: the intelligibility of the sensible. And yet “insights are a dime a dozen,” because the absolute affirmation of intelligibility requires a judgment of fact. Knowing involves a process of incremental achievements – pertaining to distinct objects of experiencing, objects of understanding, objects of judging – headed towards the realization of its final goal, the proper object of knowledge achieved in the term of rational judgment: being.

From a theoretical standpoint concerned with the elements of cognitional process, the formal identity of insight accounts for the intellectual apprehension of intelligible objects (i.e., the link between knowing and known as perfection), but the crucial level of judgment in critical realism accounts for knowledge of the other. The supposition of an epistemic bridge appears altogether misplaced and unnecessary in light of the act of understanding, which ensures that “by their very genesis concepts are united with data.”⁶⁹ And from concepts, we move to rational reflection in anticipation of the reflective insight that grasps a virtually unconditioned, i.e., a conditioned defined by verifiably fulfilled conditions.⁷⁰ Of the virtually unconditioned, Lonergan said:

once that grasp has occurred, one cannot be reasonable and yet fail to pass judgment. Again, the third level is alone decisive; until I judge, I am merely thinking; once I judge, I know; as insight draws the definite object of thought from the hazy object of experience, so judgment selects the objects of thought that are objects of knowledge.⁷¹

Lonergan’s emphatic description of judgment as “alone decisive” complements Habermas’s insistence on criticizability as the central presupposition of rationality. Where the latter emphasizes the “yes” or “no” response of a hearer in communication, the former draws our attention to the interior “yes” or “no” that answers a question for reflection (“Is it so?”) at the basis of reflective

human intelligence, not on the analogy of sense, but properly in terms of intelligence itself,” it remains that the cognitional principle under discussion allows us to explicate the relation between intelligibility and data on the level of intelligence without struggling (on some imagined bridge) between distinct sets of contents: sensible and intelligible. We will turn to the analysis of questioning later in the text. Cf. Bernard LONERGAN – “Metaphysics as Horizon.” In: *Collection. Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan*, vol. 4. Edited by Frederick E. Crowe and Robert M. Doran. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1988, p. 201. To be sure, for Lonergan, concepts are always *a posteriori*; only the “operative intelligibility of understanding,” is *a priori*. For an excellent discussion of the differences between Lonergan and Kant, cf. Giovanni B. SALA – *Lonergan and Kant: Five Essays on Human Knowledge*. Translated by Joseph Spoerl; edited by Robert M. Doran. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1994.

⁶⁹ B. LONERGAN – *Insight*, p. 364.

⁷⁰ For more on the virtually unconditioned, cf. B. LONERGAN – *Insight*, ch. 9.

⁷¹ *Ibid.*, p. 364.

understanding. Complementing the focus of communicative rationality on the linguistic medium of intersubjectivity, Lonergan suggested that language in effect *releases* consciousness by the integral role it comes to play in cognitional activity – in the sense that the scope for the kinds of possible judgments increases with linguistic ability.⁷² Without taking away from its world-structuring function, language remains, for Lonergan, an instrumental act of meaning; it expresses the cognitional achievements of knowing subjects.⁷³ If Habermas understands the reproduction of the lifeworld to occur in a circular process, then the communicative achievements of participants must, in the final analysis, retain some independence at the level of cognition – even though those achievements occur against the background of the intersubjectively shared lifeworld. Similarly, the individuating effects of the linguistic structure of communication require some account of the prior cognitional performance that allows for independence and creativity *within* language.

William Rehg recognizes that formal pragmatics and cognitional theory mutually supplement each other on these issues of judgment and intersubjectivity. When Lonergan identified the conditioned of the virtually unconditioned as the prospective judgment, he said: “At once it follows that the conditions for the prospective judgment are fulfilled when there are no further pertinent questions.”⁷⁴ Rehg argues correctly, I believe, in suggesting that formal pragmatics can aid in further exploiting the intersubjective dimension of reflective insight inasmuch as one relies upon others for calling to mind the range of questions pertinent to the affirmation of a particular judgment.⁷⁵ Again, self-critical performance seems to stress this intersubjective dimension by relying upon the “I-you” relationship constitutive of ego’s adoption of alter’s perspective. On the other side, and in complete consensus with the argument of this article, Rehg suggests that when Habermas speaks of “insight into the better argument,” he seems implicitly to presuppose the kind of reflective insight to which Lonergan attributed full knowing. Simply put, the linguistic practice of raising criticizable validity claims invariably presupposes the cognitional achievements of knowing, speaking, and acting *subjects*.

We have discussed the identity of the intellect in act and the intelligible in act and have placed the final term of knowing at the level of judgment,

⁷² Lonergan writes, “By its embodiment in language, in a set of conventional signs, meaning finds its greatest liberation.” Cf. *Method in Theology*, p. 70.

⁷³ Lonergan articulates this point with a distinction between “original meaningfulness” and “ordinary meaningfulness” and thereby distances his position from the use-theory of language proposed by Wittgenstein. Cf. *Method in Theology*, pp. 254-257.

⁷⁴ B. LONERGAN – *Insight*, p. 309.

⁷⁵ William REHG – “From Logic to Rhetoric in Science: A Formal-Pragmatic Reading of Lonergan’s *Insight*.” In: *Communication and Lonergan: Common Ground for Forging the New Age*. Edited by Thomas J. Farrell and Paul A. Soukup. Kansas City: Sheed and Ward, 1993, p. 166.

but we have yet to discuss explicitly the identity of knowing and being. The fundamental relation of cognitional activity to reality resides in intellectual curiosity, the dynamism of questioning, Aristotle's wonder. In fact, the normative pattern of conscious intentionality – experiencing, understanding, judging – follows the distinct types of *questions* that initiate the operations at each level and lead to corresponding contents. For example, a question for intelligence, "What is it?" leads to insight, and a question for reflection, "Is it so?" leads to a grasp of the virtually unconditioned. Prior to knowing, the human intellect wonders, asks questions; it desires to know. Lonergan referred to this basic yearning as the *notion of being*, because of the unrestricted horizon of its intention. As an anticipatory grasp, the notion of being always already intends its objective, being. But the capacity to inquire about anything whatsoever differs significantly from actually arriving at the goal of conscious intentionality. Lonergan offered a clear definition: "Being is what you desire to know when you inquire; it is what you are trying to conceive when you conceive; and it is what you know when you affirm it."⁷⁶ The key to critical realism, though, lies in the recognition that the notion of being "functions in knowledge as a finality."⁷⁷ It underpins, guides, and makes possible the knowing process that culminates in "the transition from intelligibility to being" with the grasp of the virtually unconditioned. Quite simply, "knowing is knowing being."⁷⁸

Not only does the Kantian supposition of the epistemic bridge appear misinformed to the Aristotelian, who argues for the primacy of perfection or identity, but also *the need* for a bridge never arises for the latter for the simple reason that the problem never presents itself. The sting of the critical question in idealism – "How does a knower get beyond herself to the known?" – disappears when the analysis of knowing begins with the *performance* of questioning and moves towards a set of rational affirmations: knowledge of oneself and knowledge of others as others.⁷⁹ One does not need to get beyond a known knower. Rather, in heading for being, the knower discovers herself and everything else she could possibly wonder about. As Lonergan writes, "questioning not only is about being but is itself being, being in its *Gelichtetheit*, being in its openness to being, being that is realizing itself through inquiry to knowing that, through knowing, it may come to loving."⁸⁰

⁷⁶ Bernard LONERGAN – *Understanding and Being*. Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan, vol. 5. Edited by Elizabeth A. Morelli and Mark D. Morelli. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1990, p. 156.

⁷⁷ Ibid., p. 169.

⁷⁸ Idem, p. 160.

⁷⁹ This set of judgments yields the principal sense of objectivity. cf. *Insight*, p. 401.

⁸⁰ B. LONERGAN – "Metaphysics as Horizon," p. 192.

The vertical finality of the dynamism of questioning characterizes subjectivity. It marks the sole *a priori* in critical realism. As the fundamental relation of knowing and being, questioning supplies the basis for identifying the real with being and objectivity with the real. Thus, Lonergan stated that “objectivity is simply the consequence of authentic subjectivity.”⁸¹ The finality of human knowing signifies a movement of self-transcendence headed towards an affirmation of reality.⁸² Accordingly, Lonergan articulated the transcendental precepts as the immanent norms of cognitional process, the interior call to authenticity: “Be attentive, Be intelligent, Be reasonable, Be responsible.”⁸³

Knowing correctly depends upon the availability of the data and the genuineness of the subject. Though formal pragmatics certainly clarifies the universal conditions for communication, it is one thing to say what actors presuppose for linguistic practices and quite another to articulate the normative exigencies of intellectual and rational consciousness. If an original instance of language involves the participants’ presupposition that force and constraint remain absent while only the cooperative quest for truth issues its demands upon discourse, then this presupposition must *compel* participants internally. An interest in the truth can originate only in the knowing, speaking, and acting subject who claims to have achieved it in raising a criticizable validity claim. Furthermore, the binding force of speech-acts depends upon the coordinating effect of the warranty offered on their behalf, because mutual understanding and agreement follow upon true affirmations. A concept of rationality guided by a telos for consensus remains deficient as long as it lacks an articulation of that upon which its goal, in fact, stands: truth.

Granted, truth can mean different things. But this does not take away from the fact that participants in communication presuppose that the validity of their claims expresses a grasp of what actually *is* the case – whether the validity of a claim pertains to normative rightness, subjective truthfulness, or propositional truth. It does not take away from the fact that participants ask questions and questions precede all validity claims. “There is wondering: What? Why? How often?”⁸⁴ And these questions pertain to anything that

⁸¹ B. LONERGAN – *Method in Theology*, p. 265.

⁸² For the sake of our comparison, we have focused strictly on the intellectual operations of experiencing, understanding and judging, with no mention of the fourth level of responsible decision. This impoverishment is felt more intensely in discussion of vertical finality. In clarification of the text above, the vertical finality of human subjectivity rests only in the inexhaustibility of unrestricted love. With the fulfillment of conscious intentionality in a state of unrestricted loving, the level of responsibility becomes the conscious ground of the existential subject. A proper treatment of these topics in comparison with the work of Habermas would require another paper. Cf. LONERGAN – *Method in Theology*, ch. 4.

⁸³ The final precept corresponds to the transcendental notion of the good of value and pertains to the conscious-intentional level of responsible decision. Cf. *Method in Theology*, p. 3.

⁸⁴ B. LONERGAN – *Understanding and Being*, p. 163.

knowing, speaking, acting subjects can ask about, anything that can enter into argumentation. "Then there is another type of question, the critical attitude with respect to the formulation: Is that right?"⁸⁵ And this question follows upon any insight into the particular (normative, expressive, objective) situation asked about. "Finally, there is grasping the unconditioned and judging."⁸⁶ And having made this affirmation truly, participants reach the absolute objectivity of judgment, true knowledge of reality, being. "There is nothing outside being that can take a look at it and have being as its object. If it is outside being, it is nothing. You move through judgment, through the unconditioned, to an absolute realm, and in that realm you find not only objects but also yourself."⁸⁷ Truth can mean different things, but if one truly desires consistency between one's cognitional performance and one's judgments, then one identifies truth with being.⁸⁸

8. On First Philosophy

Where Habermas simply neglects the fundamental question of cognition presupposed by the issue of objectivity in reaction to the Kantian model of perception, Lonergan overcame the errors of idealism without denying its achievements. The relation of cognitional activity to reality relies first and foremost not on sense perception but on the question. In its immediate intention of being, questioning provides "the constitutive principle of objectivity."⁸⁹

In his theory of communicative action, Habermas articulates the unavoidable presuppositions of communication as the basis of a concept of rationality that (1) embraces the range of linguistic possibilities, (2) focuses the internal relation of meaning and validity within a pragmatic orientation to mutual understanding, (3) accounts for the doubled character of validity claims, and (4) emphasizes the intersubjectivity of linguistic practices. In privileging the performative attitude of communication-participants, communicative

⁸⁵ Ibid., p.164.

⁸⁶ Idem.

⁸⁷ Idem, pp. 172-173.

⁸⁸ The reader may note that, in addition to his emphasis upon the objectivity of judgment, Lonergan also insists that one cannot absolutely rule out the emergence of further relevant questions in light of an otherwise satisfactory grasp of the sufficient evidence grounding a particular judgment. But note here also that this proviso of fallibility need not in any way problematize the ontological status of a correct judgment: when the analysis of knowing begins with the (empirically verifiable) dynamism of questioning (i.e. the notion of being), it ends or arrives at its full term with a correct judgment or an affirmation of the true, i.e., the medium of the real, an instance of being, the object of anticipation. Accordingly, an incorrect judgment is precisely that: incorrect. Fallibility and objectivity are not opposed or competing terms. Cf. *Insight*, pp. 308-312.

⁸⁹ B. Lonergan – "Metaphysics as Horizon," p. 203.

rationality surrenders objectivistic foundations for a scientific and fallibilist sensibility.

Though Habermas argues that the reconstructive science of formal pragmatics marks a definitive break with “the aspiration of first philosophy in any form,”⁹⁰ Lonergan identified a total and basic horizon in the unavoidable operations of conscious intentionality. And with this identification, first philosophy finds its redemption, not in a totalizing conceptualism, but in the self-appropriation of knowing, speaking and acting subjects. We discover the foundations for communication within the consciousness of the subject who raises criticizable validity claims, agrees or disagrees, cooperatively pursues truth and consensus. Ultimately, communication depends for its condition of possibility upon the yearning that the human being *is*.

⁹⁰ Jürgen HABERMAS – “Questions and Counterquestions.” In: *Habermas and Modernity*. Edited by Richard J. Bernstein. Cambridge: MIT Press, 1985, p. 196.